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# Business Psychology: Eye Contact

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As with all forms of communication, eye contact is mutually shared. Two people engage in the communication feedback loop nonverbally using only their eyes. However, the meaning of eye contact can change depending on the people who engage in it, their culture and the circumstances of their meeting.

Perhaps the most influential of our nonverbal communicative abilities, eye contact can shape another person's interpretation of you as a professional. Your eyes may also key someone in on what your unspoken thoughts about them might be.

Plenty can be inferred from one's mannerisms, but gesturing with your hands or slumping your shoulders doesn't carry the same weight as the laser beam intensity of the signals that direct eye contact transmits.

## The Power of Eye Contact Across Species



In 2007, a woman was enjoying her day at the Rotterdam Zoo in the Netherlands. She stopped by the gorilla enclosure to see the majestic silverback up close. She didn't seem to realize the social ramifications of eye contact between gorillas. Her clear attempts to attract the gorilla's attention and hold eye contact infuriated the silverback.

Zoo officials have attempted to resolve the issue by placing a sign by the enclosure. The sign requests that people not attempt to make [eye contact](#) with the apes.

## The Silverbacks of Business

It may seem strange to relate silverbacks to businessmen, but many of the same impulses exist in humans as well. Prolonged eye contact can be viewed as threatening or challenging of authority to people much as it is to gorillas.

Since eye contact has various meanings in different cultures, traveling businesspeople may want to make note of the distinctions:

- In many Asian countries, prolonged eye contact with an authority figure can be perceived as rude and provoking. Whereas avoiding eye contact may read as respect for the other person.
- In Western cultures, eye contact might be taken as [empathetic](#).
- In general, Middle Eastern cultures find eye contact [less appropriate](#) than western cultures.
- In many western European cultures, prolonged and nearly constant eye contact is considered polite.
- In America, eye contact tends to broadcast [confidence of the speaker](#).

Not surprisingly, eye contact also carries different meaning depending on gender as well. In Middle Eastern cultures, eye contact between sexes is not considered appropriate. Eye contact between women is acceptable and can be used to help convey the truthfulness of a statement. This is important to remember for traveling businesswomen.

## American Business Perception

In America, the nuances of eye contact in the workplace can take on a broad spectrum of meaning, all of which are open to much scrutiny and inference. The use of eye contact has the potential to augment people's perception of you as a person and professional.

Workers have been noted to break their gaze less when speaking to supervisors. Supervisors tend to avoid eye contact of workers as they might not care to know what the worker thinks.

Audrey Nelson explains in [Psychology Today](#), "We also know from research that high status individuals feel free to stare more at others, to look less as they listen, and to command a larger visual space. (They can look outside, down the hallway, at everyone in the room – they have a wider range.)"

Specifically avoiding eye contact may also result in a negative perception. Chron.com says, "Irregular or fragmented eye contact suggests you are nervous, lack confidence or are distracted by things going on around you. [None of these](#) are positive messages."



Forbes notes, “One hospital, analyzing letters of complaints from patients, reported that 90 percent of the complaints had to do with poor doctor eye contact, which was perceived as a [‘lack of caring.’](#)”

## Contradictory Effects

When two or more people have a disagreement, it is important to establish eye contact, but it won’t necessarily persuade those who are already skeptical of your stance. David DiSalvo explains in *Psychology Today*, “If your audience is already skeptical of your arguments, looking into your eyes will not only reinforce their skepticism, but also make them less likely to interact with others expressing your views.”

This doesn’t mean you’ll never be able to persuade those you oppose, but it will most likely require your words to be especially persuasive.

## Takeaway

Although engaging others in eye contact may seem like a risky endeavor, understand that you send out many more nonverbal cues every minute of every day. Know that prolonged eye contact may be met with hesitation or aggression, and completely avoiding eye contact may project an unwarranted disrespect to your conversational partner. Like most life experiences, yours may differ from those of others. Be conscious of the people and cultures you’re around and attempt to walk the path of empathy.

The popular YouTube Series “Take 2 to Improve with Joe Takash” explains The 5 Cs of Eye contact: Courtesy, Confidence, Concern, Command, and Comfort. If you internalize those sentiments as you speak, your eye contact should improve the outcome of your future business dealings.

## Take 2 to Improve - Importance of E...



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